circumstances ‘in national interest’. I got the drift, having read about how the Sehgal episode had deteriorated the Indo-US relations.

Media had reported when Indian cabinet secretary T S R Subramaniam and foreign secretary Salman Haider asked US ambassador Frank Wisner in January 1997 that CIA station chief Timothy Long and his deputy Susan Brown be removed. The US retaliated by asking two junior officers of R&AW at the Indian embassy’s consular section in San Francisco and Chicago to leave the country. India, obviously had some national interest in mind not to aggravate the issue. And Sehgal got to retire, albeit unceremoniously.

I did not stop with the IB director. The next year I went to a senior minister. I had heard about the minister as being a no-nonsense man. The minister had agreed for a ten-minute meeting, but it went on for more than an hour, more because of the minister beating around the bush than having any meaningful discussion.

After explaining the course of the ISRO spy case, I raised my suspicion about Ratan Sehgal having played a role in it. I asked the minister why the government let him go.

‘Let who go?’ he feigned ignorance.

‘Ratan Sehgal.’

‘Who is Ratan Sehgal?’

I knew the game by now, but played along.

‘The IB joint director who was forced to retire three years ago. And I just explained to you that he had joined IB just before the ISRO spy case was filed, and retired too soon after the case ended.’

The minister went on to quibble more before repeating the same set of words behind which the answers I sought were taking refuge: national interest.

The Union Home Ministry made an eyewash of an inquiry in late 1999 against nine IB officers including R B Sreekumar on nine counts on recommendation of the CBI. Going by the CBI’s confidential report, the other names were Mathew John, Jai Prakash, John Punnen, G S Nair, C R R Nair, V K Maini, K V Thomas and C M Ravindran. After the